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Author(s): Joan R. Acker

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Women and Stratification: A Review of Recent Literature

JOAN R. ACKER

University of Oregon, Eugene

Until six or seven years ago, women were invisible in work on social stratification, hidden in a conceptualization of female class or status derived from the class or status of men (Acker, 1973; Haug, 1973). Sex inequality was not part of the subject matter either of stratification studies focusing on individuals and their distribution in hierarchies of reward or of class studies focusing on aggregates similarly located in relationship to the system of production and the structure of economic and social power. In the ensuing years, there has been an avalanche of publications on sex inequality, much of it within the area of stratification and most in journal articles rather than books. In selectively reviewing this literature, I have been particularly interested in two questions fundamental to an assessment of progress toward stratification theory and research that illuminates the structural positions of women. First, can the disadvantaged and subordinate position of women be understood or explained within the confines of the available theories? Second, is our knowledge of class and stratification deepened, extended, or altered by the new attention to women?

The answer to the first question must be "no," unless we discard the assumption of derived status or class for women and investigate the possibilities of conceptualizing women as social beings with identities and existence of their own. It might then be possible to account for sex inequalities within stratification or class frameworks. Three different approaches to this problem are implicit, and sometimes explicit, in the literature: (1) that sex and class stratification are different phenomena and that sex inequality should not be examined at all or should be analyzed separately; (2) that women can be integrated into existing theories without substantial change in

those theories; and (3) that reconceptualization is necessary if we are to understand sex inequality.

That sex and class stratification are separate processes is implicit in much work on class. For example, a number of writers clearly think that an integration of the analysis of sex and class inequalities is not needed because women are still substantially outside the class system (Giddens, 1973) or because housewives have the class positions of their husbands (Wright, 1978); the situation of women working for pay is no different than that of men and therefore, can be accounted for with a presumably sex-neutral class analysis. These authors do not discard the old assumptions that female class is determined by the class of male relations and do not deal with sex-based inequality; by implication that subject must be discussed outside the boundaries of class analysis.

A similar implicit separation of class stratification and sex stratification appears in the proliferation of books and articles dealing with sex inequality as a separate phenomenon and geared toward the sex roles-women's studies market (e.g., Chafetz, 1974; Stoll, 1974; Deckard, 1979; Duberman, 1975; Walum, 1977; Nielsen, 1978). Class differences in the situations of women and men are described in some books (e.g., Deckard, 1979; Hacker, 1975), and the question of the relationship between sex stratification and class stratification is given brief treatment in others (Chafetz, 1974; Walum, 1977). However, the analyses do not proceed much past the declaration that women constitute a caste; the existence of these books as a separate body of literature attests to the implicit separation in the conceptual frameworks.

Recent stratification textbooks illustrate a variety of approaches to bringing sex inequality into a stratification perspective,

approaches which are vaguely specified and insufficiently elaborated. Sex inequality is variously described as "a critical form of differentiation" (Rothman, 1978), a "dimension of stratification" (Krauss, 1976), a "stratification-linked aspect of ascription" (Abrahamson, Mizruchi, and Hornung, 1976), and a "basis for stratification" (McCord and McCord, 1977). A few authors are more specific conceptualizing sex stratification and social stratification as two distinct systems of inequality (Matras, 1975; Rossides, 1976; Westergaard and Resler, 1975) with unspecified linkages. No text devotes more than a few pages to a discussion of women; theoretical issues are addressed briefly (Rossides, 1976; Abrahamson, Mizruchi, and Hornung, 1976) or scarcely at all. The texts do not successfully integrate women into the analysis and generally evade the problem by including brief descriptions of sex-based inequality generally ungrounded in a conceptualization of societal-wide stratification. Here, too, is an example of the implicit analysis of sex and class as two different types of phenomena.

Rae Lesser Blumberg's *Stratification: Socioeconomic and Sexual Inequality* is the only serious effort to date in the stratification textbook literature to integrate women into a larger theoretical framework. In a tightly argued 127 pages, Blumberg gives an historical-evolutionary account of the development of socioeconomic and sexual inequalities, deals with major theories and theoretical controversies, and develops her own theory of sexual inequality and its variation under different modes of production. She argues that women's relative economic power is the most important determinant of other inequalities including those of marriage, parenthood, and sexuality. Participation in production is a precondition for economic power. Such participation is affected by the compatibility of economic activities with child care and the availability of a suitable male labor supply. Whether or not productive work is translated into power depends on "the strategic importance and indispensability of the female producers and/or their products" (p. 27), on the kinship system, and on the relations of production. This is an intelligent and interesting book and a promising start on a theory of sex-based inequality. But, the book is short, and while Blumberg integrates women and sex inequality into her history of stratification in hunting and gathering, horticultural, and agrarian

societies, she does not do so well with industrial society. Consequently, she leaves many questions unanswered, such as why women's relative economic position is not improving today, even though women producers seem to be indispensable to modern economies. I have other difficulties with the book. Although Blumberg sets out to integrate sex and class, the theory of sexual inequality remains separate from the theory of socioeconomic inequality. In addition, although she discusses functionalist and conflict theories, she does not examine how these theories have dealt or failed to deal with women. This analytic separation of sex stratification and social stratification is certainly unintended and attests to the difficulty of the project of bringing women into stratification thinking.

Why reject the idea that sex and class stratification should be analyzed separately? Because there are conceptual ambiguities and confusions in taking this route. First, each version of such an analysis hides certain complexities. For example, to call women a separate stratum, caste, or class is to obscure the class differences among them as well as their location at the lower levels of all such groupings. Moreover, sex stratification and economic stratification are not distinct, separable categories. Sex stratification always involves economic and power inequalities; these inequalities are produced and maintained within the system of relationships that also constitutes the class structure. The situation of women within the class structure is precisely their situation within the sex structure. I would argue that the two structures are identical for women. The second problem with the "two system" analysis is that if we distinguish between women's situations as women and their fate in the class structure, we are making an underlying assumption that class or stratification is sex neutral. We do not routinely make the distinction between the socioeconomic situation of men as men and their position in the class structure. This suggests to me that class, which we take to be sex neutral, is actually a concept built on understandings of the socioeconomic world as lived by men. It may be that basic concepts, certainly those of a Marxist analysis such as exploitation and surplus value, inherently cannot make reference to sex differences. This does not mean that the concepts are sex neutral, only that they do not account for the full complexity of

the class position of women. The positing of two separate systems is a more sophisticated form of intellectual sexism than the conceptual invisibility of women. The male is still taken to be the general human being—the general societal-wide system of inequality is viewed as essentially a system of male inequality; the special position of women vis-à-vis this seemingly more inclusive structure is then analyzed separately. Women remain standing on the margins, and the subject of sex inequality is something we deal with in a paragraph, or perhaps even a chapter.

A different strategy has been used by status attainment and mobility researchers to cope with issues of sex inequality; women and sex as a variable have been absorbed into the ongoing research endeavor and its unaltered conceptual schemes. The availability of measurement tools may have been more important than the availability of theory in the direction investigation has taken. As Tyree and Hodge (1978) point out in their introduction to an issue of *Social Forces* devoted to papers on stratification, "The history of recent research in social stratification suggests that the field has been driven forward more nearly by invention of measurement than by inventions of theoretical conception." Methods and measures previously developed to study men were applied to women as soon as females came to be perceived as interesting and legitimate objects for sociological study. Publication of these studies began in the early '70s; sufficient time has passed to begin to assess how well women's disadvantaged status can be understood within this theoretical and research tradition.

The questions asked about women were the ones asked about men. Stratification researchers explored the relative social standing or occupational prestige of women and men, investigated the achieved and derived sources of female status, and compared the mobility rates and processes of males and females. In regard to status sources, when women themselves or other evaluators assess their class or social standing, the women's own occupational status is taken into account (Ritter and Hargens, 1975; Hiller and Philliber, 1978; Philliber and Hiller, 1978; Nilson, 1976). Thus, we can conclude that the social standing of married women is partly achieved and partly derived, even though the contrary findings of two studies (Felson

and Knoke, 1974; Mahoney and Richardson, 1979) suggest that that conclusion must be tentative. Other research (Rossi et al., 1974; Sampson and Rossi, 1975; Nock and Rossi, 1978) demonstrates that wives' occupational status contributes to the assessment of the position of the family as a whole. This provides further support for the argument that evaluations of the social position of women cannot be equated with evaluations of the social position of men to whom they are related. In other words, we have some empirical confirmation that women should be taken into account as independent actors in efforts to understand stratification. But, these findings do not tell us anything about the nature of sex inequality or how it is to be explained.

Comparisons of social mobility rates and processes of status attainment of women and men do say something about the nature of sex stratification, as well as something about the measures and models used. In spite of some differences in mobility patterns between the sexes (Tyree and Treas, 1974; Chase, 1975; Hauser and Featherman, 1977), the most consistent and surprising findings are that the occupational and marital mobility patterns of women are not much different from those of men, that women's mean occupational status is approximately equal to that of men, and that their processes of socioeconomic achievement—that is, the effect of education and family background on SEI achievement measures—are much the same as those of men (Treiman and Terrell, 1975a; Featherman and Hauser, 1976; McClendon, 1976).

These conclusions should not be taken as evidence of sex equality, however. For example, Hauser and Featherman (1977), in the most recent and sophisticated analysis of comparative mobility, arrive at the conclusion of similarity in mobility after removing the effects of sex differences in probability of labor force participation and sex differences in occupational distribution (p. 208). Thus, the destinations of women, where they end up in the system of rewards, is very different from that of men even though the distances from father's occupation do not differ radically for women and men. It is not surprising that few differences remain when most of the sources of difference have been removed from the analysis. The finding of equal average occupational status is also misleading, for while mean status equality may

exist at any one time, this is an artifact of the distribution of persons in jobs (Bose, 1973). In addition, the distribution of status among male and female jobs is different, with the highest status levels occupied only by jobs dominated by men (Bose, 1973). There is also evidence that men experience a rise in status over the life cycle, while women stay at about the same occupational levels from the beginning to the end of their working lives (Wolf and Rosenfeld, 1978).

Further, whatever status equality may exist at any one time, the income disadvantages suffered by women are severe and persistent, and women are not rewarded for status increases with higher incomes as men are (Featherman and Hauser, 1976: 478; Suter and Miller, 1973; Treiman and Terrell, 1975). Status attainment research showing at any one time both prestige parity and income inequality between the sexes leads to two questions about the adequacy of this stratification approach for understanding sex inequality. First, what is the meaning of the concept of status or prestige, given these contrasting findings in regard to sex stratification? Second, how adequate is this stratification model for explaining sex inequality?

"What do prestige scales scale?" (Hauser and Featherman, 1977:5). This is not a new question. Hauser and Featherman (1977) were willing to concede to Goldthorpe and Hope (1972) that prestige scales represent "a hierarchy of desirability rather than of prestige" (Hauser and Featherman, 1977:5), but they argue that underlying that desirability is a hierarchical socioeconomic structure. Prestige scores stand for relative desirability which, in turn, represents socioeconomic differences, presumably such things as income, authority, and expertise. The problem is that women and men with similar occupational prestige scores do not have similar incomes (Treiman and Terrell, 1975a; Featherman and Hauser, 1976) or similar authority in the workplace (Wolf and Fligstein, 1979). They may also be in occupations with substantially different task requirements (McLaughlin, 1978). If there is a difference between women and men on the underlying socioeconomic dimensions while their prestige scores do not differ, what are we to conclude about prestige scores? One answer is that prestige scores, and socioeconomic indices, represent a hierarchical socioeconomic ordering of males; e.g.,

Duncan SEI scores (Duncan, 1961) are ultimately based on a study of occupational prestige from which female occupations were largely excluded and the equations for the SEI scores were derived from male earnings and education for each of the occupations (Bose, 1973; Haug, 1977). When females are assigned occupational status scores constructed in that way, the scores will not be congruent with the incomes, degrees of authority, or actual responsibilities of female occupations or of female workers. Perhaps prestige scores measure different things for women and men in other ways. The desirability of women's occupations might be judged on different criteria than men's occupations. Bose's (1973) careful and detailed study of sex differences in occupational prestige provides some evidence on this question. She finds that percent female in a job and the fact that the job incumbent is a woman raises the social standing of some jobs (pp. 68-72), but the effect is small and it varies with her two samples, a college and a community population. This could be interpreted to mean that, on the whole, people assess women workers and female-dominated jobs on the same implicit grounds that they use to assess men workers and male-dominated jobs (Wolf and Fligstein, 1979), that sex does not make a great difference in the social standing of occupations.

Before coming to that conclusion, we must deal with the anomaly of the housewife. Bose (1973) and Nilson (1978) have gathered data on the prestige attributed to the housewife. Both find, contrary to the generally accepted view and the findings of at least one qualitative study (Oakley, 1974), that housewives are accorded a surprisingly high prestige score. Bose found that the status of the housewife is higher than that of 70% of other female occupations. In Nilson's study, respondents rated the housewife as comparable in prestige to a reporter, a bookkeeper, and an insurance agent, placing her in the middle ranges of the female occupations. Yet, this is an occupation with no income and with incumbents whose education spans the whole range of possible levels. How can it be rated at all? There must be criteria of desirability other than socioeconomic standing in the minds of those who rate the status of the housewife. Rosenfeld (1978a) suggests that this is so and that such a score for housewife is not useful because it

"confuses prestige rewards obtained within the occupational structure with prestige obtained otherwise" (Rosenfeld, 1978a:40). If the prestige accorded to the housewife is obtained otherwise, it does not represent her true socioeconomic position. What does the housewife's score reflect? Probably the generalized perception that the role of housewife is an honorable one for women. It may also indicate that women, as women, are given a middling sort of respect in our society.

Could it be that one of the sources of prestige attributed to other predominantly female occupations is in the generalized respect that women earn as mothers and wives? This would help to explain why it is that equal occupational status does not result in equal incomes or authority. The usual explanation, articulated by McClen-don (1976) among others, is that female concentration in white-collar jobs accounts for their status parity with men; the nature of the white-collar job confers prestige even in the absence of wages as high as those in other jobs of equal standing. An additional explanation might be that female dominated white-collar jobs have inflated prestige scores because they are female dominated, and that this underlying basis for evaluation was not tapped by the experimental and statistical techniques used by Bose.

Whatever the underlying dimensions of prestige scores may be, their meaning is ambiguous. It is clear, however, that they do not reflect sex inequality accurately in the domain of paid work and that they are even more inadequate as a tool for understanding the system-wide structuring of sex stratification, because the socioeconomic disadvantages of the housewife role cannot be measured with indices of social standing. In spite of all the critiques, a number of researchers continue to use these measures and to argue their suitability in studies of women (e.g., Wolf and Fligstein, 1979; Rosenfeld, 1978b).

It is not only the measures, but also the underlying model of social stratification in the status attainment perspective, that obscures the nature of sex inequality. As Horan (1978) points out, occupational status scores assume a unidimensional hierarchy of positions and the conceptualization of the status attainment process is rooted in the functionalist stratification tradition as well as in human capital theory of neo-classical economics. These theories

"assume an open, fully competitive market process in which individual characteristics are identified and rewarded according to their societal value . . ." (Horan, 1978:536). The assumptions of a unidimensional hierarchy and an open competitive process are not tenable in the case of women and men. The fact that status is not related to income or authority in the same way for women and for men, as noted above, indicates that unidimensionality is suspect. The data showing a sex segregated labor force and wage discrimination is not consistent with an assumption of an open competitive process between the sexes. The problem is not resolved by adding family variables and measures of length and continuity of labor force participation to status attainment models (Ayella and Williamson, 1976; Falk and Cosby, 1975; Hudis, 1976; Rosenfeld, 1978b). Even though the unpaid work of women is integral to the problem of sex inequality, adding it on in this way does not alter the implicit assumptions about the occupational-economic system. All of this suggests that the interesting and potentially useful questions are not how individuals get into certain slots, but how the structure itself is formed and what its changing contours are.

In search of a more structural analysis, some investigators are turning to dual economy and labor market segmentation theory (Bibb and Form, 1977; Beck, Horan, and Tolbert, 1978). Using a structural model that differentiates between core and periphery sectors of the economy and comparing it with a human capital model, Bibb and Form (1977) find that the structural model explains almost three times as much variance in blue-collar earnings as a human capital model. Beck, Horan, and Tolbert (1978) investigate the hypothesis that low wages in the periphery are due to the lack of human capital of workers found there. They conclude that "there is a considerable cost borne by periphery workers over and above that which we can account for by the quality of that labor. Likewise, there is a substantial gain for workers in the core which cannot be explained by their labor force characteristics" (p. 174). It is not so much the characteristics of the workers (although they play a part) as where they are working that accounts for income differences. Since women are disproportionately in the peripheral industries, this location explains some of the earnings discrepancies between the sexes.

But the dual economy notion alone does not explain sex stratification satisfactorily. Sex strata have an effect independent of sectoral location. For example, sex of the worker—which stands for a concept of sex as an estate—rather than other structural factors is the most important variable in Bibb and Form's structural model. When they disaggregate their data by sex, they are able to explain only 18% of the earnings variance for men and 24.4% of the earnings variance for women, as compared with 50.3% of the variance explained in the analysis with the sexes combined. Beck, Horan, and Tolbert show that women (and minorities) face a wage disadvantage vis-à-vis white males in the core sector, but that they do not suffer a disadvantage in the periphery over and above the disadvantages of being in that sector, "which they share with white males" (p. 716).

The earnings disadvantage suffered by females in the core sector suggests that the sex segregation of occupations may be greater there. The importance of sex segregation for the position of women has been recognized by numerous publications (*Signs*, 1976; Lloyd, 1975; Blau, 1978), and the processes internal to the workplace which help to perpetuate it are beginning to be studied (Kanter, 1977; Cassell, Director, and Doctors, 1975; Steinberg, 1975), but sex segregation has not made much impact on mainstream conceptualizations of stratification. There is some work underway that may have such an impact. For example, Snyder and Hudis (1976) try to explain the low incomes of occupations with high proportions of women and minority male workers using 20-year longitudinal data. They conclude that neither competition nor segregation processes are very important over such a short time period and outline an ambitious project of investigating the sources of sex segregation with comparative and historical data. Such studies, along with more detailed investigations of the differences in the characteristics of female dominated and male dominated jobs as well as the mobility between these sectors (Wolf and Rosenfeld, 1978; also see Treiman and Terrell, 1975b), should deepen our knowledge of the paid occupational structure.

To sum up the argument to this point: the attempt to integrate women into stratification theory and research of the status attainment variety has contributed to the increasingly frequent critiques of the under-

lying theoretical framework and the measures related to it. Structural analyses have begun to illuminate sources of sex inequality other than those located in individuals. Sex divisions in the production system emerge as structural characteristics over time (Oppenheimer, 1970; Snyder and Hudis, 1976) and present individual women and men with different work realities. It is not just that women constitute a disadvantaged estate (Bibb and Form, 1977), but that the structure itself is constituted in terms of sex differentiation, and this has consequences for men as well as for women (Villemez, 1977; Treiman and Terrell, 1975b; Wolf and Rosenfeld, 1978; Feuerberg, 1978).

While these structural models do not come out of a Marxist paradigm, they are not inconsistent with certain Marxist analyses. An examination of the ways that Marxists have dealt with sex and class reveals they, too, have had trouble locating women in the structures of inequality and oppression. The literature on this problem is voluminous, more theoretical than empirical, and produced more often by British writers than Americans. The question turns on the particular position of women in the class structure. Given that class is determined by the relations of (commodity) production, it is women's position in that type of production which is most essential to understand, and which is basic to exploitation and inequality, according to the classical Marxist view. Thus, one strategy has been to analyze women as paid workers, ignoring for the most part the other half of women's lives (e.g., Wright, 1978; Braverman, 1974; Giddens, 1973; Poulantzas, 1978), and essentially defining as outside the class system those women who are full-time housewives.

Marx's analysis of the reserve army of labor has provided one way of accounting for women's continuing subordination under capitalism. The capitalist economy continually generates a reserve of labor and that reserve is made up disproportionately of women (see Beechey, 1978 for one application of this concept to women). Simmeral (1978) argues persuasively that women have constituted both a secular and a cyclical reserve army. As a secular reserve army, they were the labor force available for particular processes of expansion in capitalist production. This seems to be a reasonable interpretation of, for example, the rapid growth of the clerical labor force and

therefore sheds some light on the historical roots of sex segregation in that sector. Simmeral also argues that women have constituted a cyclical reserve, entering the labor force when demand was high and leaving when demand contracted. She counters the critics of this position who point out that women have never been a labor reserve for men's jobs (e.g., Milkman, 1976) by saying that women do not have to substitute directly for men in order to have an effect on the market and on the overall wage rate (p. 168). It also seems that women are increasingly only a reserve for female-dominated jobs and that in a sex segregated labor force there are male dominated jobs with wages unaffected by female workers, who in no way are competing for those jobs.

There are problems with the attempts to explain female disadvantage solely on the basis of an analysis of the processes of capital expansion and capital accumulation. For one thing, we cannot understand women's situation in the industrial reserve army without taking into account the unpaid labor of women or their role in the reproduction of the labor force. The housewife intrudes in Marxist as in stratification analyses and demands to be included in the development of an adequate class theory. What has become known as "the political economy of domestic labour debate" has centered around arguments that the woman's unpaid labor reproduces the labor force and therefore contributes directly or indirectly to the production of surplus value and the accumulation of capital (Coulson et al., 1975; Gardiner, 1975, 1976; Seccombe, 1974; Smith, 1978). This formulation places woman within the class structure by establishing that she has a relationship to the means of production even if she is exclusively out of the wage system. But, this line of thinking ultimately produces a curiously functional explanation—women are relegated to unpaid labor because of the interests of capital. In my view, the analysis does not take us much closer to understanding the underlying dynamic that produces both unpaid labor in the home and wage inequality at work. The value of these attempts to analyze domestic labor may be in their affirmation that women's unpaid labor is socially necessary and that it must be related to women's paid labor in order to understand the totality of the situation of women in the class system.

The identification of patriarchy as the structure of the domination of women and the exploration of the relationships between patriarchy and various modes of production has been the analytic strategy of another group working within a Marxist perspective. They argue that there are two structures, capitalism and patriarchy, that are interrelated in complex ways and that must be analyzed together in order to understand the position of women (Rowbotham, 1973; Hartmann, 1976; Eisenstein, 1979; McDonough and Harrison, 1978; Kuhn, 1978). The capitalism-patriarchy formulation has developed in two directions, based on the answer to a critical question—what are the material bases of patriarchy? One direction is rooted in the argument that the material bases of patriarchy are in the system of reproduction and in human sexuality. Efforts to explain the perpetuation of male control in both these spheres lead to a fascination with Freud and the reproduction of the unconscious processes of domination. The other direction roots patriarchy in the objective economic interests of men, which cut across class interest. Hartmann's (1976) work is a good example of this approach. The argument is that capitalism develops out of a previously patriarchal society and preserves patriarchy as part of the system of control. In the process of development, male workers gain a privileged position in the wage-based economy by denying women access to apprenticeships and jobs in male dominated, unionized fields and by pushing for protective legislation that further excludes women. Thus, as the economy develops, it emerges with a sex segregated occupational structure. This historical interpretation helps to answer some of the questions left unanswered by reserve army of labor theories—specifically, if women would work for less than men, why don't employers always prefer them? Eisenstein (1979) argues that patriarchy is the political system of control which serves the purposes of the capitalist economic system, the locus of the generation of class. There is an interdependence between the two systems, with patriarchy assuming new forms as the development of industrial capitalism advances. Patriarchy persists not only because it constitutes the control structure, but also because males gain or have gained in the past.

The idea of capitalist patriarchy (Eisenstein, 1979) or of patriarchal capitalism, is, it

seems to me, an advance over ideas of sex stratification and class stratification as two separate systems. But, I am not sure that it avoids the problems of the two-systems analyses in that the analysis of class under capitalism can be left relatively undisturbed, with patriarchy invoked when we want to talk about the "special" situation of women. Ultimately, these efforts to understand sex inequality with a theory of patriarchy melded into a Marxist theory of capitalism pose problems for Marxist theory itself. If patriarchy persists across modes of production, we must entertain the possibility that there is something more fundamental about human societies than labor, material life, and the mode of production. Alternately, we can argue that patriarchy has a material base, is rooted in a particular mode of production which is not capitalist but which persists into capitalism. The problem with this is to explain why a no longer dominant mode of production should have such a significant impact. To argue that patriarchy is based in male interests that cut across class is also to pose theoretical problems. What are those interests? Are they ideological or material, or both? Whatever direction socialist feminism takes, the implications are for a major revision of Marxist class theory because women do domestic labor and do not enter the paid labor force on the same terms as men. Therefore, the concepts and theories used to understand male labor are not sex neutral and are not adequate for the analysis of women. Pending such a reconceptualization, some useful examinations of women's position in the class structure as defined by location in paid labor are appearing. Garnsey (1978) and West (1978) provide excellent summaries.

In concluding this review, I will look briefly at how a consideration of the position of women in the class system can expand and clarify our understanding of the development of and the present structuring of class stratification. I want to go even further and suggest that it is impossible to understand the past or the present when attention is paid only to men. For example, it can be argued that the historical development of capitalist production was as dependent on the unpaid and paid labor of women as on the labor of men. Present day manifestations of this are documented in studies of women's labor in some developing countries where the unpaid agricultural labor of women allows men to be employed

at very low wages (e.g., Boserup, 1970; Deere, 1976).

In today's society, the understanding of the significance of white-collar work—and white-collar work as women's work—is critical to understanding class structure and the potential for class consciousness and class organization (Garnsey, 1978). As West (1978:235) comments, "The Marxist analysis of classes in capitalism has certain grey areas, precisely those which centre on the critical significance of 'white-collar' labour, and specifically whether it is now part of an expanded proletariat or is the new element of a distinct class, the *petite bourgeoisie*." There is no consensus on this; Braverman's (1974) discussion of the transformation of white-collar work argues powerfully for proletarianization; Giddens (1973) sees the feminization of the white-collar sector as a major factor in turning it into a buffer zone between the working and middle classes; Poulantzas (1975) argues for the new *petite bourgeoisie* position. That many female (and male) white-collar workers are working class is given some support by Vanneman (1977), while Wright and Perrone (1977) and Robinson and Kelley (1979) report that higher proportions of women are working class, using their objective measures, than are men.

The degree of openness in the structure cannot be assessed without considering women. I have criticized mobility studies above, but that is not to say that they are useless if they are conceived in such a way that questions are relevant to women (e.g., Wolf and Rosenfeld, 1978). The patterning of inequality between families is also affected by the contribution of wage earning women (Treas and Walther, 1978). Changes in family composition may also be changing the class structure, with a growing disadvantaged sector or lowest stratum, composed of mother-headed households (Glazer, 1976; Hoffman, 1977). Class consciousness cannot be understood without understanding the consciousness of women, and not as simply conservative laggards behind more militant husbands, but as people who have a particular situation that produces a particular view of the world (Smith, 1977; Porter, 1978). There are indications, for example, that the manual-nonmanual dividing line is not relevant for women in defining their own class position (Vanneman and Pampel, 1977), reflecting perhaps, the changing nature of some female dominated jobs. The sex-based divi-

sion of labor may produce bases for conflict within classes. For example, there is evidence that males gain from sexism (Villemez, 1977; Feuerberg, 1978). As Feuerberg points out, men may not know that they gain, and women may not know this either, but such knowledge could lead to efforts to preserve male privilege now as in the past. Recent court challenges to affirmative action suggest that white men know that they gain from both sexism and racism; this cannot be ignored by class analyses. Finally, the feminist insight about the patriarchal nature of control systems is important and must be taken into account in any effort to understand the overall structuring of inequality.

Conclusions

Stratification theory has been a theory of white males. Such a theory becomes more obviously inadequate as white males become more and more a minority (numerical) in the labor force. A vast literature related to women and stratification has appeared in the last few years. This work can provide the basis for a new and better understanding of class stratification. A theory that includes women will have to conceptually bridge the gap between women's unpaid and paid labor and bring the structural sources of sex inequality into the analysis. We have yet to see a sex-integrated treatment of class stratification. That is work for the future.

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Explaining Inequality: A Survey of Perspectives Represented in Introductory Sociology Textbooks

WAYNE J. VILLEMEZ
University of Illinois, Chicago Circle

Purely individualistic explanations of inequality have increasingly been called into question in recent years. Both human capital theorists in economics and status attainment modelers in sociology have been

seriously challenged by those who contend that structural factors are far more powerful determinants of individual inequality than are the characteristics of individuals.

Burawoy (1977) has echoed Coser's